

Assignment 2

Ling 201 – Spring 2026

(100 pts total)

Part 1: Parts of Speech. (6 points/sentence, 24 points total)

- a. The smart sailor quickly repaired the boat and sailed away
 D Adj N Adv V D N Conj V Adv
- b. The tall teacher carefully opened the window and smiled kindly
 D Adj N Adv V D N Conj V Adv
- c. birds can fly because they have light bones and wings
 N T V Conj/C N V Adj N Conj N
- d. I know that a young leopard can run very fast
 N V C D Adj N T V Adv Adv

Part 2: Constituency Tests. (6 points each/36 points total)

1. The small dog chased the frightened cat.

It is NOT a constituent.

- * It is small dog chased that the the frightened cat. [movement]
- * The small dog chased and big cat protected the frightened cat [coordination]
- * The what the frightened cat? [stand-alone]

2. She walked quickly to the neighborhood park.

It is NOT a constituent.

- It is to the neighborhood park that she walked quickly [movement]
- Where did she walk quickly? to the neighborhood park [stand-alone]
- She walked quickly there. [replacement]

3. **The boy** ran very fast home.

It is a constituent.

It is <u>the boy</u> who ran very fast home.	[movement]
<u>The boy</u> is who ran very fast home.	[movement]
Who ran very fast home? <u>The boy</u> .	[stand-alone]
<u>The boy and the father</u> ran very fast home.	[coordination]
<u>He</u> ran very fast home.	[replacement]

4. They saw **a big red balloon** near the trees.

It is a constituent.

It is <u>a big red balloon</u> that they saw near the trees.	[movement]
<u>A big red balloon</u> is what they saw near the trees.	[movement]
What did they see near the trees? <u>A big red balloon</u> .	[stand-alone]
They saw <u>a big red balloon and a small yellow ball</u> near the trees.	[coordination]
They saw <u>it</u> near the trees.	[replacement]

5. The girl sang a beautiful song in **the sunny garden**.

It is a constituent.

It is <u>the sunny garden</u> that the girl sang a beautiful song in.	[movement]
<u>The sunny garden</u> is that the girl sang a beautiful song in.	[movement]
What did the girl sing a beautiful song in? <u>The sunny garden</u> .	[stand-alone]
The girl sang a beautiful song in <u>it</u> .	[replacement]

6. He ate the pizza **with extra** pepperoni.

It is NOT a constituent.

* It is <u>with extra</u> that he ate the pizza pepperoni.	[movement]
* <u>With extra</u> is what he ate the pizza pepperoni.	[movement]
* What did he ate pizza pepperoni? <u>Pizza Pepperoni</u> .	[stand-alone]
* He ate the pizza <u>with extra and without salted pepperoni</u> .	[coordination]

Part 3: Structural Ambiguity. (10 points/item, 40 points total)

- a. The spy saw the agent with the binoculars on the roof.

The spy saw the agent who was on the roof and who had the binoculars.

- b. The spy saw the agent with the binoculars on the roof.

The spy who was on the roof saw the agent who had the binoculars.

- c. The spy saw the agent with the binoculars on the roof.

The spy who was on the roof used the binoculars to see the agent.

- d. The spy saw the agent with the binoculars on the roof.

The spy used the binoculars that were on the roof to see the agent.

Extra Credit (5 points)

In addition to the four interpretations above, consider the colour-coded sentence below:

* The spy saw the agent with the binoculars on the roof.

If you think it does not work:

This reading is logically possible but **not the preferred interpretation** in English. English listeners strongly prefer attaching a **modifier** to the **nearest** noun. So, the sentence is first parsed as: the agent with the binoculars, instead of the spy with the binoculars.

To obtain the intended hard reading, the listener must mentally detach with the binoculars from agent and reinterpret it as modifying saw / spy. That extra processing effort makes the reading feel **less natural**.

If you think it works:

We can paraphrase it to make it more understandable: Using binoculars, the spy saw the agent, who was on the roof. The phrase with the binoculars can modify saw and if we have a clear context as follow:

“The spy grabbed the binoculars. The spy saw the agent with the binoculars on the roof.”

Then the context can bias the reading and how we actually pronounce the sentence might also give us a less ambiguous interpretation.